Business Letters

Introduction to Letter Writing

Letter writing is one of the most important forms of written communication. Despite the rise of emails, WhatsApp, and other digital communication tools, letters still play a vital role in academic, professional, and business communication.

Letters are used to:

- Communicate formally
- Share information
- Make requests
- Give instructions
- Maintain professional relationships
- Record communication for future reference

In business, letters serve as official and legal documents. Therefore, they must be written carefully, clearly, and professionally.

Nature of Letters

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1) **Written Form of Communication**

   Letters are written messages sent from one person to another. They are more permanent than spoken communication.

   Example: A manager writes a letter to an employee regarding promotion.

   This communication is recorded and can be used later.

Nature of Letters

2) Formal and Informal Nature

Letters may be:

Formal Letters

These are official letters written for business, academic, or professional purposes.

Examples:

Business letters

Job applications

Complaint letters

Official requests

Nature of Letters

2) Formal and Informal Nature

Letters may be:

Informal Letters

These are personal letters written to friends and family.

Examples:

Letter to a friend

Letter to parents

Invitation letters

Nature of Letters

3) Permanent Record

Letters serve as written proof of communication. They can be stored and used as legal evidence if needed.

Example:

- Appointment letter
- Offer letter
- Complaint letter

These letters can be used as official records.

Nature of Letters

4) Structured Communication

Letters follow a proper structure. This makes communication clear and organized.

Typical Structure of a Letter:

- Sender's Address
- Date
- Receiver's Address
- Subject
- Salutation
- Body of Letter
- Closing
- Signature

Nature of Letters

5) One-way Communication

Letters are usually one way communication. The sender writes first and the receiver replies later.

Unlike face to face communication, letters do not allow immediate feedback.

Nature of Letters

6) Professional Tone

Business letters use polite, respectful, and professional language.

Example: Instead of writing: “Send me the documents quickly.”

Write: “Kindly send the required documents at your earliest convenience.”

FUNCTIONS OF LETTERS

Functions of Letters

1) Providing Information

Letters are used to provide information clearly and formally.

Examples:

- Announcement letters
- Notification letters
- Circular letters

Example: A company informs customers about a new product.

Functions of Letters

2) Making Requests

Letters are used to request something formally.

Examples:

- Application for leave
- Request for information
- Request for documents

Example: A student writes a letter to the principal requesting leave.

Functions of Letters

3) Placing Orders

Business letters are used to place orders for goods or services.

Example:

A shopkeeper writes to a company to order products.

Functions of Letters

4) Complaints and Claims

Letters are used to report problems or make complaints.

Examples:

- Complaint about damaged goods
- Complaint about poor service

Functions of Letters

5) Maintaining Business Relationships

Letters help maintain professional relationships between:

- Companies
- Customers
- Employees
- Suppliers

Example: Thank you letters help build goodwill.

Functions of Letters

6) Legal Documentation

Business letters serve as legal documents.

Examples:

- Contract letters
- Agreement letters
- Appointment letters

These letters may be used in legal matters.

Functions of Letters

7) Persuasion

Letters are used to persuade or convince someone.

Examples:

- Sales letters
- Promotional letters
- Recommendation letters

Functions of Letters

8) Confirmation

Letters are used to confirm previous communication.

Example: Confirming meeting schedule

Confirming order

Confirming payment

Types of Business Letters

Work with a partner. Review some different types of business letters. Which letters have you written or received in the past? Which types of letters are you most likely to write? Can you think of any other types of business letters?

1. Inquiry

In this type of letter, you ask a question about a product, service, or policy.

2. Resignation

In this type of letter, you notify a supervisor or manager that you are planning on leaving/quitting your job. You may or may not state a reason.

3. Cover

This type of letter comes before a resume when you are applying for a job. It is a short letter of introduction that doubles as a thank you note.

4. Reference

This is a letter that you write for someone else. You may provide a personal or a business reference. In this letter, you state how long you have known the person and why you recommend him or her, usually for a new job or position. You may include the person's strengths.

5. Thank You

There are a variety of reasons why you might need to send a thank you letter in a business situation. You may want to thank a company for good service, or you may want to show appreciation for a colleague who has worked with you on a project.

6. Complaint

In this type of letter, you state concerns or disappointment about goods, services, or business-related issues. It is important to remain polite. Do not use ALL CAPS or inappropriate language. Don't send a letter of complaint while you are angry. Reread your letter and decide at a later time if you should send it or not.

7. Request

There are a variety of things you may need to make a request for in business, including internally (e.g., a deadline extension, a reference letter) or externally (e.g., a contact name, a replacement part).

8. Confirmation or Follow-Up

This is a letter to confirm that something has been received. Occasionally email or packages go missing or end up in a spam mailbox. Don't follow up too quickly.

9. Sales or Marketing

Businesses send many letters to potential customers or clients to introduce new products or make special announcements. These are often written by a president or CEO of a company.

10. Notification

In this type of letter, a company, organization, or individual may provide information about a person's account, membership, or job position. Notifications may be about updates or changes. They may contain good or bad news for the recipient.

WRITING THE BASIC BUSINESS LETTER

Parts of a Business Letter

Sender's Address

The sender's address usually is included in letterhead. If you are not using letterhead, include the sender's address at the top of the letter one line above the date. Do not write the sender's name or title, as it is included in the letter's closing. Include only the street address, city, and zip code.

Parts of a Business Letter

Sender's Address

A. Sender's Information

Are you using letterhead? Letterhead is stationery with your business name and address already printed on it. If you aren't using letterhead, type your company name and address in the top left corner of your paper.

Example

Stand-Up Desks, Inc.
22 Wakefield Dr.
Rochester, NY 95402-4560

Task 1

Look up a local business and write the address on the lines below.

_____

_____

_____

Parts of a Business Letter

Date

The date line is used to indicate the date the letter was written. However, if your letter is completed over a number of days, use the date it was finished in the date line. When writing to companies within the United States, use the American date format. (The United States-based convention for formatting a date places the month before the day. For example: June 11, 2001.) Write out the month, day and year two inches from the top of the page. Depending which format you are using for your letter, either left justify the date or tab to the center point and type the date. In the latter case, include the sender's address in letterhead, rather than left-justified.

Parts of a Business Letter

DATE

B. Date

After the sender's information, leave a space.
Then write the date using one of the formats below.
In the US, the order of the date is: month/day/year.

Date Formats:

- March 4, 2019
- March 4th, 2019
- Mar 4, 2019
- Monday, March 4, 2019

Task 2

Practice writing some dates:

1. Write today's date.

   _____

2. Write the date of your next birthday.

   _____

3. Write the date six months from today.

   _____

Parts of a Business Letter

Inside Address

The inside address is the recipient's address. It is always best to write to a specific individual at the firm to which you are writing. If you do not have the person's name, do some research by calling the company or speaking with employees from the company. Include a personal title such as Ms., Mrs., Mr., or Dr. Follow a woman's preference in being addressed as Miss, Mrs., or Ms. If you are unsure of a woman's preference in being addressed, use Ms. If there is a possibility that the person to whom you are writing is a Dr. or has some other title, use that title. Usually, people will not mind being addressed by a higher title than they actually possess. For international addresses, type the name of the country in all-capital letters on the last line. The inside address begins one line below the date. It should be left justified, no matter which format you are using.

Parts of a Business Letter

C. Recipient's Information

After the date, leave another space. Now add your recipient's name, title, and address. Triple-check that you spelled the name of the company and recipient exactly as it should be.

Example

Mrs. Alley Freeman
Director of Sales
Furniture Forever
3 Main St.
Rochester, NY 14605

Parts of a Business Letter

Salutation

Use the same name as the inside address, including the personal title. If you know the person and typically address them by their first name, it is acceptable to use only the first name in the salutation (for example: Dear Lucy:). In all other cases, however, use the personal title and last/family name followed by a colon. Leave one line blank after the salutation.

If you don't know a reader's gender, use a nonsexist salutation, such as their job title followed by the receiver's name. It is also acceptable to use the full name in a salutation if you cannot determine gender. For example, you might write Dear Chris Harmon: if you were unsure of Chris's gender.

Parts of a Business Letter

D. Salutation

Leave a space after your recipient's address. Then add your salutation. Make sure that you spell the recipient's name correctly. Punctuation after Mr., Ms., or Mrs. is common, but it is also possible without (Mr or Mrs). Use a comma (,) or colon (:) after the salutation.

Business Formal

- Dear Mr. Miller,
- Dear Ms. Hampton,
- Dear Mrs. Wu:
- Dear Sir,
- Dear Madam,
- To Whom It May Concern:
- Dear Frederick Carlyle,

Business Casual
(between colleagues)

- Good morning,
- Good afternoon,
- Hello,
- Hi Erica,

Parts of a Business Letter

Body

For block and modified block formats, single space and left justify each paragraph within the body of the letter. Leave a blank line between each paragraph. When writing a business letter, be careful to remember that conciseness is very important. In the first paragraph, consider a friendly opening and then a statement of the main point. The next paragraph should begin justifying the importance of the main point. In the next few paragraphs, continue justification with background information and supporting details. The closing paragraph should restate the purpose of the letter and, in some cases, request some type of action.

Parts of a Business Letter

E. Body

Leave a space after your salutation and then start the body of your letter. A business letter should be separated into paragraphs. Each paragraph should be about a single subject. One or two paragraphs may be enough. Use plain text (without indentation). It is common to leave a space between paragraphs.

Tips

Start with a friendly greeting. Introduce yourself (if it's the first time you've contacted this person). Be cordial (polite) even if it is a letter of complaint.
[space]

Identify your reason for the letter.
Use more than one paragraph if necessary.
[space]

Provide any special information. Identify any attachments if it's an email. If applicable, state exactly what you want or need from the recipient.

Parts of a Business Letter

Closing

The closing begins at the same vertical point as your date and one line after the last body paragraph. Capitalize the first word only (for example: Thank you) and leave four lines between the closing and the sender's name for a signature. If a colon follows the salutation, a comma should follow the closing; otherwise, there is no punctuation after the closing.

Parts of a Business Letter

F. Closing

Leave a space after the final body paragraph. Then write a closing phrase (this is optional). Leave another space and write a closing word(s), followed by a comma. On the next line, add your name and title. Add a phone number if you want to be contacted by phone. Sign your name by hand if it's a printed letter. Print your name and title beneath your signature.

Closing Phrases (optional)

- I look forward to your reply.
- I apologize for the inconvenience.
- I look forward to meeting you.
- Should you need further assistance, please don't hesitate to ask.
- Thank you for your immediate attention.

Closing words

- Sincerely,
- Respectfully,
- Best,
- Best regards,
- Best wishes,
- Warm regards,
- Thank you,
- Sincerely,

Example

I look forward to your reply.

Sincerely,



Helen Hayes, Administrator

Parts of a Business Letter

Enclosures

If you have enclosed any documents along with the letter, such as a resume, you indicate this simply by typing *Enclosures* below the closing. As an option, you may list the name of each document you are including in the envelope. For instance, if you have included many documents and need to ensure that the recipient is aware of each document, it may be a good idea to list the names.

A Note About Format and Font

Block Format

When writing business letters, you must pay special attention to the format and font used. The most common layout of a business letter is known as block format. Using this format, the entire letter is left justified and single spaced except for a double space between paragraphs.

SAMPLE 1: FULL BLOCK FORMAT
(SAMPLE FELLOWSHIP APPLICATION LETTER)

HEADING (your address and date)	20-54 Jackson Avenue Brooklyn, NY 11352 June 28, 2007
ADDRESS (of the person you are writing to)	Ms. Jennifer Esposito John Doe Fellowship 595 Park Avenue New York, NY 10021
SALUTATION	Dear Ms. Esposito:
BODY	The John Doe Fellowship has always loomed on the horizon for me. Ever since I decided to major in history, I have wanted to participate in your program. From the research that I have done, I believe that your program provides its participants with an extensively detailed look at the history of the world through hands-on experience with fossils, artifacts, and other remains that compose the blueprint of our existence. I am applying for the John Doe Fellowship because I believe that it would benefit me throughout my career and allow me to further understand the ideas behind history and how it is constructed. I am a very committed and goal-oriented person with excellent interpersonal skills. My background in history involves studying many different eras and time periods. My specialty, though, is the archeological study of the ancient world and its history. During the summer of 2004 and 2005, I interned at the Metropolitan Museum of Art as a tour guide. Both times, I not only utilized my knowledge of art and its history, but I also learned a lot about how that history was constructed. This experience has influenced me to intern as a tour guide at the American Museum of Natural History, where my love for the origins of history and learning from the tactile experience with artifacts increased. In the future, I would like to participate in historical research and eventually become a full-time professor of history. I believe my skills, experience, and goals make me an excellent candidate for your program. Thank you very much for considering me for the John Doe Fellowship. I am looking forward to hearing from you.
COMPLIMENTARY CLOSE	Sincerely,
IDENTIFICATION LINE TITLE OR PHONE NUMBER	Bill Lurie (419) 352-5425
SIGNATURE	
ENCLOSURES OR DISTRIBUTION	Enclosure

A Note About Format and Font

Modified Block

Another widely utilized format is known as modified block format. In this type, the body of the letter and the sender's and recipient's addresses are left justified and single-spaced. However, for the date and closing, tab to the center point and begin to type.

SAMPLE 2: MODIFIED BLOCK FORMAT (SAMPLE CPE APPEAL)

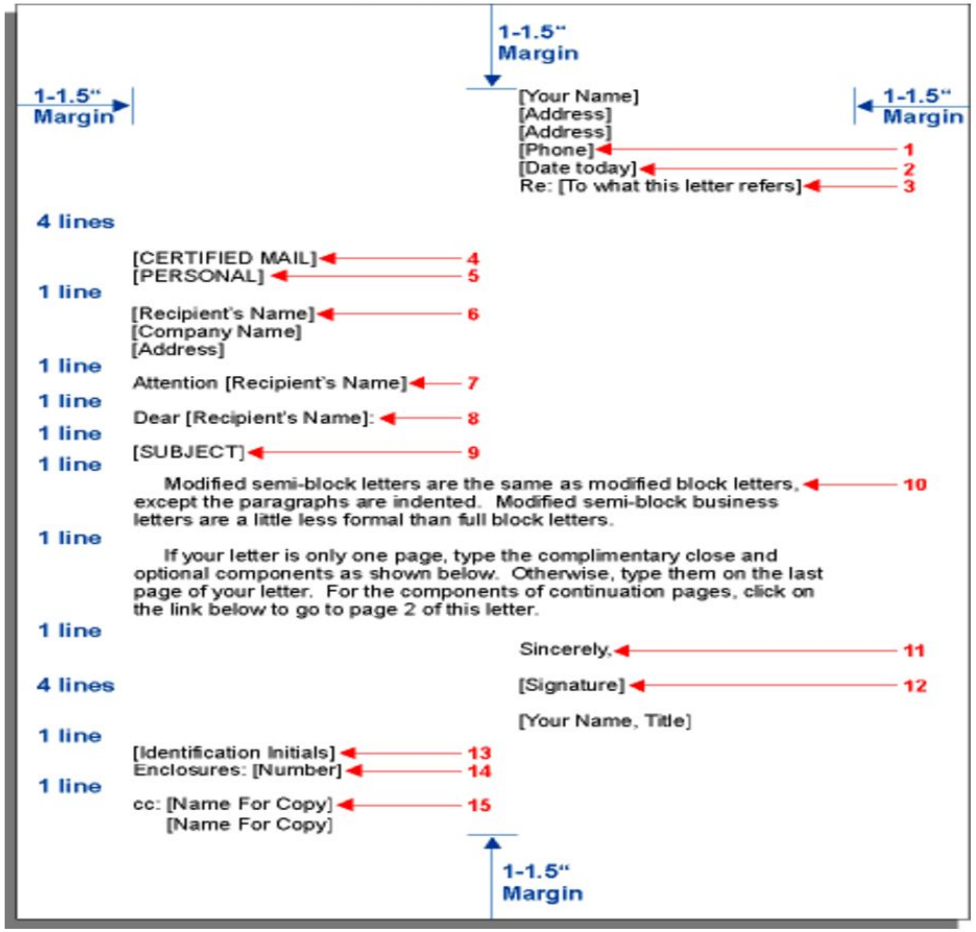
HEADING (Your address and date)	123 Corona Blvd. Flushing, NY 11235 July 3, 2007
ADDRESS (of the person you are writing)	Dr. Steven Serafin, Director Reading/Writing Center Hunter College 695 Park Ave New York, NY 10065
SALUTATION	Dear Dr. Serafin:
BODY	My name is Sally Eisner. I am writing this appeal to request a 4th chance to take the CUNY Proficiency Exam in June of 2007. I have taken the exam twice and missed it once. The first time, I feel that I was simply unprepared. I did not realize that I should have attended CPE workshops offered at the Reading/Writing Center. The second time, I attended the workshops and learned more about the exam; however, my Task 2 score was unsatisfactory, so I failed again. Finally, I registered for CPE tutoring at the Reading/Writing Center and studied very hard for the third time. However, on the Saturday of the exam, I had a family emergency, which caused me to miss the date. I had forgotten that I could defer the test date until after I missed it. Now, I am working hard to build on my academic skills. After a consultation with a CPE advisor at the Reading/Writing Center, I have a clear vision of what I should do in order to pass the exam. Again, I have registered for a semester of CPE tutoring at the Writing/Reading Center that I plan to attend weekly. I would really like to have a 4th chance to pass this exam because I am confident that if I work hard, I can do it. Thank you very much for considering my appeal. I hope to hear back from you soon.
COMPLIMENTARY CLOSE	Sincerely,
SIGNATURE **IDENTIFICATION**	Sally Eisner

A Note About Format and Font

Semi-Block

The final, and least used, style is semi-block. It is much like the modified block style except that each paragraph is indented instead of left justified.

Modified Semi-block format



A Note About Format and Font

Font

Another important factor in the readability of a letter is the font. The generally accepted font is Times New Roman, size 12, although other fonts such as Arial may be used. When choosing a font, always consider your audience. If you are writing to a conservative company, you may want to use Times New Roman. However, if you are writing to a more liberal company, you have a little more freedom when choosing fonts.

A Note About Format and Font

Punctuation

Punctuation after the salutation and closing - use a colon (:) after the salutation (never a comma) and a comma (,) after the closing. In some circumstances, you may also use a less common format, known as open punctuation. For this style, punctuation is excluded after the salutation and the closing.

Business Letter Checklist

BEFORE SENDING YOUR LETTER

After you write your letter, proofread it. If it is an email, don't send it right away. Leave it in your drafts folder and come back a little later to open it again. Fix any mistakes you see. Check your spelling! If you are happy with your letter, hit "Send" or "Print." If you're mailing the letter through a postal service, be sure to use correct formatting on the envelope.

- ☐ Did I type the recipient's name and address correctly?
- ☐ Did I include a proper salutation?
- ☐ Did I write politely even if it is a complaint or concern?
- ☐ Did I trim any unnecessary words or lines?
- ☐ Did I close the letter appropriately with my needs clearly stated?
- ☐ Did I include contact information for a reply?
- ☐ Did I proofread my letter?
- ☐ Did I wait a day before sending a letter of complaint?
- ☐ Did I format the envelope properly?

Pair Activity

A. Write a Business Letter

Write a letter of complaint to a manager of a company that you recently made a purchase from. Express your dissatisfaction with the product in a polite way. Include the sender, recipient, subject, salutation, body, and closing. Be sure to use useful expressions from this lesson. Use this space for your rough draft.

Proofread your letter later today or tomorrow. Refer to the checklist! (You could also type your letter on a computer and print it.) Then write or type an envelope with a fictional address and exchange your letter with your partner.

B. Write a Reply

Respond to your partner's letter. Use this space for your rough draft. Be sure to use useful expressions from this lesson. Write or type an envelope using the return address from the envelope you received from your partner. Give your letter of response to your partner.